Aunt's aren't gentle!

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/29381781.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Jeeves & Wooster, Jeeves - P. G. Wodehouse

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra)

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by the_Frank

Summary

It's the height of the jazz age and London is as swinging as it can be, as the roaring twenties roar on.
Adora S. Greyskull, young, rich, sporty, the definition of a loafer and maybe not the most intelligent of the bunch lives her life happy and sorrowless.

Unfortunately she has wilder friends, like Mermista Anastassakis, or indeed Glimmer Little, who keeps roping her into the most fantastic schemes. Not to mention her fearsome aunt Sharon Weaver who wants Adora to do her bidding at any cost and often with the threat of violence should she fail.

Luckily for Adora, she has an ace up her sleeve. Her trusted valet, her Gentlewomans Gentlewoman, the inimitable Catra to help her out of any sticky situation.

Cover art by MUSTLOVEFROGS

https://www.deviantart.com/mustlovefrogs/art/COM-Jeeves-and-Wooster-871731703

Notes

Perhaps you have wondered "what if Adora and Catra would show up in the world of P.G Wodehouse?"

Wonder no longer. Here it is.

With invaluable advice from Bagge and encouraging shouting from Jezmatron.

If you want to get into the right kind of mood:
https://youtu.be/8cWvwkqDCWQ

Chapter 1

Aunts aren't gentle!

By the Frank



So, I lay there in bed and just felt "Hullo, I can't be laying here! There's a whole day out there that just waits to be day-ed by me!" So I jumped out of bed and rushed to the old bathroom to prepare for this day. Washing myself behind and in front of the old ears, and, well you know what happens next,then as I looked into the mirror I felt that this was the day to try something I sported just the other day.

I had, if I may so say, quite the schedule to follow. Wednesday was fencing, Tuesday was Rugby, Monday was the day of free weight lifting and Sunday, oh glorious Sunday was riding day when I could jump my noble steed and penetrate the Woodlands

and what not in endeavour of nature or something like that. Swift Wind is his name, by the way, an excellent example of a horse. Tennis goes in between all of that, needless to say. Now, this day was Thursday, by the way, the so to speak 'free' day, but I usually had a few rounds of boxing planned, but it wasn't regular. Just almost every week. But I was talking about Swift Wind! Yes!

I tell you, he always knows when I am coming, as the petrol horse makes it's turn on the plot outside the stables I can always hear his neighs, saluting me and welcoming me. I swear ,I can just say his name and I can hear him neigh. Even when I am at home. We are as synchronized as master and horse can be! He's the noblest of noble steeds, and believe me, I have seen more than my share of them. He may not be one of the Queens quadruplets, but should they be introduced, he can nobble with the best of them.

'Darn it, I will make him a visit today' I thought to myself, but then I realised that would make the whole point of my appearance null and void. You see, I am equipped with rather long hair, which I take meticulously care of, as the code of the Greyskulls say. All my living relatives have long shiny hair of all colors and nuances. I usually keep it free and flowing, but today I decided to sport a ponytail. While that is nothing unusual when I go to the stables (it makes the riding helmet much more comfortable, how on earth something so uncomfortable could be that) or when I play polo (which is Friday, by the way, meaning I had just one more day left before me and Swifty would crush our opponents in the most exquisite game ever made up by man!) but yesterday I spotted a girl sporting one in bright daylight right in the city! That was indeed something and all eyes were on her! And so, with a swift notion and a hair tie, my own hair was in the very same do as hers. I looked at myself in the mirror and said "You, Adora S. Greyskull is one heck of a Johnny!" After that it was out and get dressed, sporting the usual attire of unmentionables, dark blue socks , white shirt, tie and my dark green skirt dress. A Gentlewoman must never dress under her station, you must honor the ham and eggs!

Breakfast was indeed around the corner, as I entered the kitchen, I found my man Catra aligning the cutlery straight. Technically I suppose she should be addressed as my maid, but since she always wears a full jacket suit I have simply decided to refer to her as my Valet. My gentlewoman's man, my doer of does and the chappiest chap of them all. She is remarkable. She has the brain of a wonderchild and Einstein combined and she has saved me from danger and ruin more often than I dare to count. "Ah. Good morning, miss Grey...skull." She looked up from the table and froze as she saw my appearance. I smiled jovially at her, this was as I said a day-y day!

"Good morning, Catra! Why, this splendid morning just got splendider. Is there possibly any scones for today?"

"No miss, unfortunately they were out of flour yesterday, so I haven’t been able to bake. I was forced to run down to the french bakery down Buchanan Street. Perhaps a croissant a chocolate would be a suitable substitute?"

I rubbed my hands in voluptuary anticipation.

"Even better!" I said, and sat down. "Say, has anything happened worth mentioning before breakfast?"

"No miss. The developments in Indochina don't look well, but I hardly expect that to have any impact on you."

"Jolly good! Jolly good," I exclaimed as I finished my baked goodie and proceeded to dig into my omelette. As Catra had served my tea I noticed the queer look in her eyes.

"You didn’t inform me you were going horse riding today, miss."

Ah. Here it was. You see, Catra is in almost every inch the perfect servant. But she has these peculiar views on how I should dress and how to look. I say, there are days when I get the distinct feeling of having a wife instead of a servant! I admit, I am a bit submissive towards her, since she has helped me so many times,

but today I wasn't going to go under her thumb! My ponytail was there to stay, and that was it! It was time to put my foot down.

"I am indeed not. Today I have only scheduled lunch and boxing with Mista, but the rest is as free as the children of Plumeria!"

"I see, miss. In that case, perhaps you should adjust your hairdo. "

"Indeed? Why?" Best attack is defense!

"Your ponytail, miss."

"Are you implying that my ponytail is improper?" I gathered all the authority I could muster. It was time to show the silk fist under the iron glove, or whatever they say.

"No miss, I am saying it right out that it is."

"I'll have you know that this is the latest in fashion!"

"I believe there has been a mix-up of latest and too late, miss."

"Look here, Catra. This is my appearance for today and I don't want another word in the matter! Is that clear?"

"Yes miss." She turned away to fetch the butter, rolling her eyes, which I chose to ignore. I gave her a disapproving eye, but it did not disappear. I sighed and decided that she would have to get accustomed to it! I was the woman of this household and it was time to show Catra who's in charge!

"I suggest you take the car to your lunch, Miss Greyskull. Otherwise they might mistake you for a bell strap on the underground." she said with a smirk. While Catra is as servile as they come, she has a rather mean streak and a sharp tongue that no education in the world can erase.

"Now Catra! You…

But she was already out the door. I sighed, and shrugged. The battle was on, and I still had my hair the way I wanted. She may have won a battle, but dang it -she was to lose the war!

Breakfast done I went down to the garage to fetch my car, but I decided against it. I was not going to let Catra control my every move! She needed to be shown her place! The looks I received on my way downtown to the princess club was everything I could expect. I smiled to the world and the world smiled back at me!

As I arrived, I went straight to my locker and got my boxing gear out. I changed and went for the rings where Mista already awaited me. She raised her eyebrows as she saw me.

"Ponytail, Greyskull? Are you that eager for Catra to yank your head down for a smooch?"

I frowned. Mista (Well, actually Mermista Philomena Augusta Anastassakis III, but she threatens to beat up anyone who uses her full name) always sneaks in some frivolous comment about me and Catra. Sometimes it’s just the hair that separates her from a sailor.

"This, my dear Mermista, is fashion. You would know that if you read anything other than detective novels!"

"Yeah, whatever. Are you ready to get your ass handed to you?"

She bumped her gloves together as she got her tooth-protection put in place by her maid.

"Hah! I will have you on the floor in three rounds, I would like an early lunch!"

Our match did in fact last five rounds and I dare to say that it was a close call, but in the end I won. But I give it to Mista, it was just barely. She is as good a fighter as she is a brilliant businesswoman!

As we stood in the showers afterward to freshen up before lunch, I complimented her.

"That combination of a left jab with two quick right ones really took me by surprise, old chap! I say, I was indeed lucky to avoid them."

"Yeah, whatever."

"I hear that young Frosta is interested in joining the club? I suppose there will be a hearing about it next month?"

"Whatever."

Alright, now I knew something was ajar. You see, joining the princess club isn't easy, you have to have the right connections and the right papers and even then the house committee needs to have a hearing about it. Mermista is on the board and she is always up for some gossip about every aspiring candidate.

I finished the starter (A delicious toast with whitefish roe), put down my fork and looked Mista right in the eye.

"Old gal, you are way off. What is darkening the sky for you today?"

She glared at me.

"That ponytail looks stupid."

"It does not! And don't change the subject!"

"...I am moving. Probably"

I raised my eyebrows. "Indeed? Were?"

"We bought this bungalow up in Bedforshire. Nothing really. Just ten rooms and 54 acres of land. Perfect for hunting."

"Oh! Well, jolly good! Splendid! The fresh air and open space of the country, am I Right?"

"Whatever."

Mermista gave me a look that told me she appreciated my greyskullian wit as much as she enjoyed wet paper bags thrown into her face on a rainy Wednesday morning. Truth be told, I WAS surprised. You see, Mermistas father was a Shipowner, actually THE shipowner of London. Salineas Ltd. made so much money they could fill the Firth of Forth with it, and knowing Mermista she would probably try if she could. She herself took over the company a few years back. Now, I don't know anything about that sort of stuff, but Catra says she makes enough money to use gold when her duty is done. She is also born in the sea and buying a house on land isn't like her. She says she is fond of hunting, but I have yet to see her use anything other than a harpoon.

"Alright, I have to say it, Mista! This is very much not you. You hate hunting. The country? Is that really necessary?" She was silent and glared at the waitress for a while, making the poor thing in turn refill our bread basket, wine glasses, give us new spoons and ask if we wanted another tablecloth or if we disliked the colour of the napkins before she stopped and answered.

"I am being thrown out of Sea Gate. ...well, We are."

"Blimey! That's not very cricket of your old man!"

Sea Gate is her father's mansion, you see. It could probably house the passengers and crew of Titanic and the Olympic if necessary, and it sort of looks like the prow of an Atlantic steamer, if you can picture it on top of a cliff, 175 feet above the sea. Mermista has her own wing there and has had for as long as I have known her. She also has an impeccable relationship with her old man, since she is, well, a financial genius. But old Anastassakis loves his house. I began to have my suspicions.

"Mista," I said, "I can't shake off the distinct feeling that there is more to this story than you are telling me."

"Whatever."

"It's just this gut feeling that I have."

"Whatever, I said."

"It's funny, really. When you get a hunch of something and you just know it's fishy, you know."

"Adora. To be frank. Go sit on a rusty nail and rotate." She was silent for a bit again and then she murmured: "Sea Hawk. It's all his fault."

Ah. The old Greyskull brain didn't let me down a one-way street! It was as I suspected, then. Sea hawk, you see, is Mermistas husband. She married far below her station, not that the man isn't attractive or charming, but he has a strange tendency to cause accidents. I rarely enjoy quoting Catra, but she once called him 'A blabbering imbecile who thinks that a non-burning house is a wasted potential.' Of course, she didn't use that polite wording.

"Tell me everything!" I ejaculated.

She glared at me. "Adora. You can't help anyway."

"Because it's too hard?"

"Because you're an idiot."

I must say, that even if I gave the old gal some slack, since the shock must have been enormous, I did feel the need to protest. "Mista. Now, you see. That wasn't very…"

"Adora."

"Yes?"

"Shut up."

"Yes."

She was silent again. "It's… He had his 'crew' over for dinner."

"Ah! Say no more!" I could see where this was going.

"They barely got to the main course before he declared that the wine was wrong and that they needed to venture down to the wine cellar."

"Ah! Say no more!"

"They armed themselves with Cutlery and a few knick-knacks from the wall."

"Ah! Say…"

"ADORA! SHUT. UP."

"I will say no more."

"Good." I held my promise. She continued. "They declared our old butler 'a fiend and an unjust servant of the John Bull' when he insisted that he could bring the bottle and that they didn't need to smash the door to the wine cellar in. Poor Jarvis… Hopefully his neck will stop hurting…"

"...What did they do to him?"

"They tied him up and forced him to walk the plank. In the library. "

"By jove! Did he survive?"

"...How do you even breathe… Anyway, apparently they opened a few bottles down there 'to celebrate their good luck' and on the way up… they set fire to the pool room."

"They did that?"

"...Okay, He did. Luckily, Jarvis got out from the ropes and alerted the whole staff. They extinguished the fire and took down the guests and my dear husband." She paused. "Apparently, my chambermaid has a mean left hook."

"Wow. I say, if they did something like that, I understand that your father has…" she gave me another of her patented 'I wish you turned into a pile of gallic turd'-looks. "I mean, a bit overreacting from his side, really!"

She sighed. "No… You're right and my husband is a moran."

"Why did you even marry him if that's how he makes you?"

"He looks extremely good next to me."

"Is that all?"

"No, he also has a big schlong. Anyway, the main reason is that while they did manage to save the pool room, during the commotion, Sea Hawk was pushed into the grandfather's clock, causing it to fall over. Now it's broken."

"Awfully inconvenient to place a clock there, I say."

She blinked at me and then proceeded to cover her eyes with her hand. "...My god, there *is* two of you…"

"Say what?"

"Nothing. Anyway, apparently that clock was extremely rare. Made by Henson, Benson and Swanson in Swansea."

"Never heard of the firm."

"According to father, 'the worst clockmakers in the history of man and perhaps even horses.' But the few they made are extremely rare and cost a ton to get."

"...Are you talking about the dark grey piece in the corner with the mirrored face that always struck 12 at teatime?"

"The very same."

"How can that one be so expensive?"

"I dunno. But I need to find one. Or else we have to move."

I blinked. " I thought you wanted to move."

"Adora. Can you see ME living in BEDFORSHIRE? I REQUIRE the open sea and the wind in my hair to live!"

At times it is remarkable how well she and Seahawk match together.

"I need to get one of those clocks so my old man lets us stay. And I will do anything, Greyskull. ANYTHING. To get one." She stared at me with a look I felt in the back of my skull.

"Come now, old gal! You wouldn't murder for it, would you?"

She placed a finger on my chest. "Anything."

I must say I was glad when I returned to the old lair to find Catra ready with a nice little cocktail for me.

"Oh dear me I needed that."

"I expected as much, miss. Mrs Anastassakis probably took advantage of your… Hairdo… during the boxing game to bring you to a humiliating defeat."

"Catra…" I emptied the glass. It was exactly what I needed. "No, it was nothing like that! And she complimented my hair! At least sort off. No, she was in great distress, you see!"

"Ah yes. The blubbering fool of a husband of hers managed to get in another idiotic mess, I heard, miss Greyskull."

"Catra… Also, how did you know?"

"Mrs Anastassakis chambermaid Huntara and I share the same club, miss. She told me all."

"Ah. She has a mean left hook, apparently. "

"Indeed she has, miss. You would not last a minute against her in the ring."

"Catra! That was uncalled for! ...Could you arrange it? I would love some hard resistance."

She smirked. "Certainly miss. I would love to see you get your ass handed to you."

"Catra…"

"Another cocktail, miss?"

"No, I think that is enough. Oh, has anything happened during my absence?"

"There was a telegram, miss. I took the liberty to read it. You aunt, Mrs Shadow Weaver is in town. She will come to see you later today."

I felt the blood rush to my feet. "Give me another one. Two actually! Whiskey! Pure whiskey!!"

She bowed. "Right away, miss."

"And it's SHARON Weaver, Catra," I murmured, but I hadn't the energy to rebuke her. Besides, she is not wrong. Aunt Sharon could fill in for one of the riders of the apocalypse any day without needing more than a change of shoes. When she wants to see me it always means trouble. Even if she is polite and ...sort of pleasant, she always gives me a feeling of dread. Catra hates her. I should scold her for her outspoken hostility, it is not her place to be vocal about it. But… I can't in my right mind do so. The woman is a beast.

The beast… I mean Aunt Sharon arrived a little after tea.

"Mrs Shadow Weaver has arrived, miss. Shall I prepare refreshments?"

"Sharon, Catra… And yes, do bring it in! Biscuits, sandwiches, the goods you know!"

"And some cyanide for our guest. I will be quick, miss."

"Catra…" But she was already out the door. Aunt Sharon entered. She dominates every room she enters. She is taller than everyone, always wears red (making her look like you are going to meet the spanish inquisition really.) And sports dark glasses, meaning you can't really see her eyes, or mouth for that part. She wears a veil. Why I don't know, she looks perfectly normal underneath it. Catra says it's because she wants to hide her fangs. I have told her time and time again not to be disrespectful but… ah well.

"Adora… My dear niece…"

"Why, hello aunt Sharon! What gives me the pleasure?"

"The pleasure is all yours, dear. Is the tea ready?"

"Oh yes! Catra is preparing it right now."

"I see. Good thing I ate before I came. Anyway. I need your help."

"Oh? With what? I must say I am awfully busy you know…"

"No you're not. I need you to get me a Henson, Benson and Swanson clock." I blinked.

"Um… "

"Oh my dear Adora… You do know what that is, right?"

"Oh! Oh yes! Certainly! I will just stroll down to Harrods and get you one, he he."

"Adora, my dear… You're not getting it at Harrods."

"Oh? So… where can I find one?"

"Mrs Little-Gore has one. I want you to get it for me."

Ah. Now it sort of made sense. Mrs Angella Little-Gore is my aunt's arch-enemy. She is richer, has a nicer house, a nicer husband and is overall a much more successful version of my aunt. So if she has one, of course Auntie needs one. But still, it didn't make sense. Luckily, by then, Catra entered with the tea.

"Refreshments, miss Greyskull. Mrs Weaver. A sandwich, perhaps?"

"Why, thank you Catra! Tea, Aunt Sharon?"

"One cup then. "

"Very well mrs.Weaver. milk? Lemon? Arsenic?" I had to check. No, there was absolutley no grin on her face.

"Lemon."

"Suitable, Mrs weaver."

"Catra…"

"I apologise, *miss Greyskull* ." She made a huge affair of only looking at me, and then she left.

"You should get rid of that wench, Adore! Such impertinence! Such attitude!"

"She has her sides but…"

"Never mind. I know you will defend her no matter what. Now I need to be brief, I have a meeting with my solicitor in 25 minutes. Get me Angella's clock. Before next Friday. Or else…"

Then she ate five sandwiches and two muffins in rapid order before she left. I immediately rang for Catra to take out the tea and give me something stronger.

"It is remarkable, Catra," I said, after I had a few more glasses of brandy to heal, "that not only did Aunt Sharon ask for that clock,

but also Mista. I say, what is the deal with them?"

"I hear they yield a not insubstantial value, miss."

"Really? For that piece of worthless junk?"

"Yes, miss. I do know a bit about the firm in question, Miss. It consisted of a few lords that all had inherited their fathers wealth but not their capacity of constructing sustainable pieces. This clock was the brain work of mr. Swanson I believe. The idea was to make a clock that would always show the time you wanted it to show."

"Oh dear me."

"Indeed, miss. Well, apparently one of the buyers was a lord who refused to accept he had bought unfit goods and he insisted on the thing being a spectacular curiosity. So he insured it for a hefty sum and put it behind glass. And no one dared to question his claim that it was a rarity as he said, meaning that everyone else wanted one. Last time I heard the price was up to 296 guineas for a complete one."

"Oh dear me. That is a sum! So the firm survived due to the money they got from that?"

"No miss. All of the owners died during the demonstration of their last invention. The steam powered submarine."

"...Oh."

"Apparently mr. Swanson's Widow sold the clocks and moved to America where she invested it all in a new type of counting machine. She is very wealthy, I hear."

"All's well that ends well, uh, Catra?"

"Indeed miss." She made a delicate paus?. "Your hair is in a bit of disarray after your exercise with Mrs. Anastassakis. Perhaps I should brush it for you? I will also take care of that hair tie and…"

"No! I will brush it myself!"

I more felt than saw the second of today's eyerolls. "Very well, miss…" and she left.

I saw her 30 minutes later, all dressed up to the sevens. She is a servant after all.

"With your permission, I am going out."

"Out? Now?"

"Today there is the board meeting and a meeting with the membership committee at my club *The Horde*, miss. I told you last week."

"Oh. Yes, you probably did. Well, off you go to conspire how to poison your masters!"

"I will, Miss. I will probably not return until later. I suggest you book a table for dinner. Good evening, miss Greyskull."

And off she went.

She had only been gone for around 20 minutes, but I was already feeling a bit uneasy. Partly because I couldn't make up my mind what to have for dinner, but most of it was because of my aunt's orders. How the devil was I supposed to get that clock for her? From my memory, it was a rather big piece, and it wouldn't be easy to get out from the Brightmoon Estate, where Lady and Lord Little-Gore lived. And then came the question how to get there. Well, the oblivious answer was by car, but that would only solve the transport, really. To actually get admission to the premise would be a bit of a snatch. I do know Lady Little-gore a little, and I did go to school with her daughter, but it would be easier with a random visit to her, than actually go to Brightmoon.

After a long and deep thought I decided that the curry lamb down at the Cow and chicken would be sufficient, along with a good

pint of their best bitter. And after that, there was only one thing to do! Go to bed.

End of part 1

Chapter 2

One good night of sleep later, but I wasn't closer to a solution. So, time for plan B then. Whenever I need to clear my head, I go down to The Plumeria estate. They have a large farm with cows and chickens and ducks and what have you. And a stable, where I keep my noble steed, Swift Wind. Considering Catra hadn't been in when I wanted to discuss the matter, I had to cook up something myself. Trouble is, I am not especially good at that. Give me some fencing equipment, or a rugby ball, or some boxing gloves any day, and I know my way around it! But these matters… I tend to overthink matters and make it more complicated than necessary. But a turn in the woods with Swifty always clears my head.

The old boy was as urgent to go out in the wild as I was. I almost didn’t get to saddle him before he was out of the box, and that is always a good sign! We were out for maybe one hour, since it was late afternoon. On our way over the barnyard, I heard someone call my name.

"Adora!"

I stopped Swift wind and looked in the direction of the call. I instantly recognised the caller. There is just one person in London who is short but dresses like she is tall, my old friend and comrade, Glimmer Little. Always purple, always high heels, always long robes. Save for a wig, she looks like she could be a judge in a Lewis Carroll-story. She is probably my best friend in this world, save for Mista. And Catra.

"What ho, Glimmer! What brings you to Plumeria? Are you here to see Perfuma?"

"I was yes. But now I am here to talk to you."

"Me? But how could you know I was here?"

"I didn't. I saw your car."

"Oh. Yes, that makes sense."

"Of course it does. Anyway, I need to ask you a favour. I need you to come with me and visit mommy and daddy this weekend."

I thanked the gods above, under and around for this stroke of luck! Here I had… Well, if nothing else, the opportunity to at least look at the goods in question.

“I would be delighted! They still have that french master chef, what’s his name…”

“Anatole. And yes, they do. But don’t wet your palates too much, Adora. I need you to do something for me.”

“Anything, old gal! What?”

“You will see. ...Oh, could you give me a ride back to London? I forgot to buy the return ticket.”

During the ride she refused to say what the matter was, and we chatted about old school memories all the way. Catra didn’t return home until late, and so it wasn’t until Lunch that I could inform her of the plans for the weekend.

"Very well miss. I will pack the necessary items."

"And don't forget the hair ties!"

She gave me a long look. "Very well, miss Greyskull…"

As Catra left to get the bags, the phone rang. It was Aunt Sharon.

"Why, good morning Auntie!"

"It's well over noon, Adora. Spare me your nonsense. I am in a hurry, so I will be brief. You haven't got any second thoughts are you? Come up with some lame excuse why you can't do this?"

"Um…"

"Figures. Listen here, my dear niece. You will get me that clock by next Friday or I will RIP your hair out. By the roor. Every strand. Is that clear?"

I swallowed. "Yes, Auntie."

"Good. Have a nice day, Adora."

I hung up. "Catra."

She appeared next to me. "Miss?"

"Aunt Sharon just called. Threatened me to RIP out my hair if I didn't get her that clock."

"Indeed miss? Well, not surprising coming from a defeated wench like her." I glanced at her, but there was no sneer. Apparently she considered this a fact.

Even if I couldn't say I felt encouraged, I did what I always do, I confided in Catra. I told her everything.

"Hmmm." She.said.

"Well, hmm indeed!"

"This is a rather pertinent matter, Miss. I must say that at the very moment I am not quite sure what actions must be taken."

"Oh come one, Catra! Don't give me that! You always have a plan, your fish-fueled brain can perform miracles!"

I noticed a slight blush on her cheeks and she bowed. "Thank you, miss. I do not enjoy disappointing you. However, at the moment there are too many variables to give an exact answer. There might be certain development to happen, it’s even presumptive, but I need to be sure."

"Well, what is it?"

"I'd prefer not to say right now.".

"Come now, Catra…"

"I assure you, Miss, once I am certain of the order of events, you will be the first to know." While she was as polite as anyone could ask, this wasn't what I needed to hear. I was frankly disappointed and I was not going to hide it!

"Catra! This is honestly not like you at all! Sure, you may not have a plan in the very instant, but you've had at least 15 minutes to think! Isn't there something I can do? Escape to America, or perhaps a cruise, or join the army… Maybe not that. But anyway! Some remote relative that requires my company so I don't have to get that dreadful thing for Auntie." Catra did look a bit uneasy, but her answer came with her usual security.

"I would strongly advise against fleeing the field, Miss. Mrs Weaver is not easy to persuade in changing her priorities, and while a change is possible, it would take some six to nine months. "

"Blimey. That's quite a long time to stay out of the old country, isn't it?"

"Quite so, miss. I strongly recommend that you fulfill your promise and go to Brightmoon. Now, if that is all, Miss Greyskull…"

I waved her off and proceeded to my bathroom for my travel preparations. But I was in a foul mood. Damn the woman! Normally she would have me out of this in no time. I knew what this was about! It was my ponytail that caused her refusal to help me. Well! If she thought I would give in so easily, she didn't understand how the mind of a Greyskull worked! I would get through this mess without Catras help! That would show her!

The drive down was quick, I took out some of my frustrations through a few rather frivolous maneuvers with the old vehicle. We crossed the speed limit by at least 25% at times. Catra had a bit of a jam holding onto her hat, but otherwise she was silent.

As we arrived in Brightmoon both Lady and Lord Little-Gore was welcoming us.

"What ho, your Lordship! And Ladyship as well!"

“It is wonderful to see you, miss Greyskull. It has indeed been too long since last time. Hasn’t it, Micah?”

“Oh yes! Yes dear! It has indeed!”

“We should invite you more often, but since Glimmer moved to her own place...Well you understand. Juliana will show you to your rooms. I guess you would like to freshen up before dinner?”

“Yes , thank you! Get the old traveling dust aside and switch it for...well, not dust since your place looks really clean but… Well, you know.”

She smiled. “I know. I shall walk with you there, I would like to know what you have been up to lately. Micah?”

“Whu? Oh yes yes. Jolly good to have you here! Jolly good. You go ahead, I need to check out the gardeners. But you are most welcome here. Most welcome! Ah but Miss Greyskull?” He called after me as we walked up to the gate. “No queer business like last time, got that? Ha ha!”

There is a saying that elephants never forget. Well, Lord Little-gore is definitely an elephant. It’s what-can-it-be three years since that debacle with the saucepan and I swear that it took two years to actually get to cut up my food myself.

Lady Little-Gore on the other hand is a pleasure to talk to, she is a brilliant conversationalist. Unfortunately I can't recall in the slightest what we were talking about. And then it was time to prepare for the evening. I withdraw to my designated room, bringing Catra along to choose the right toilet. That did take me some time since I wanted to be my best. A Greyskull always dresses in style, even when she is to steal a clock. Finally the first gong rang and I rose from my bed. Catra was ready outside and

she looked, as always, stunning in her well-pressed smoking as she opened the door to my room. "Ready, miss Greyskull?"

"Lead me there!"

But as I came down the stairs, another surprising view awaited me. In a darkish greenish dress and a smoking no less. It was Mermista and Sea Hawk in their own low person!

"What ho, Mista? What is the meaning of this?"

"Adora! My my, this is a surprise!" Sea Hawk greeted me in his normal extravagant way, while Mista facepalmed. "Have you come to join us? We are here… on an ADVENTURE!"

"Sea hawk… can it."

"Everything for you my dear." He proceeded to kiss her hand and work his way up to her shoulder. He is like that, and Mermista blushed, but she didn't protest.

"But why are you here?"

Mista leaned closer to me and whispered:"I said I wanted that clock at any price, right?"

I looked back at her in surprise. I replied in a similar whisper: "Yes, but I can't imagine Lord Little-Gore selling it."

"I know. We are here to steal it. And you will help me."

End of part 2.

Chapter 3

"Steal it? Now, Mista … Isn't that a tad bit drastic?"

"I want it. I am going to have it. They won't sell it. What else can I do?"

"...Not steal it?"

She gave me a blank stare.

"Do you perhaps have a Henson, Benson and Swanson clock hidden somewhere in your apartment, Greyskull?"

"...Not that I know about, no…"

"In that case I suggest you to keep those lips shut."

"Um. Yes. Well."

"You're still talking, Greyskull."

"Ehrm… Mermistaaa?" Sea Hawk sing-sang his way into our conversation.

"You be silent too, Husband. When I need you I will tell you." He removed himself from the scene, but I wasn't ready to leave the subject just yet.

"But, now, Mista! I really…"

"Found a clock in your underpants, Greyskull?"

I blushed. "MERMISTA! What ho?"

Mista rolled her eyes. "Oh, stop being such a baby. You can hear the word u…" She paused. "...What are you doing here by the way?"

"Me?"

"Yes, you. The rest live here. What's your excuse?"

"Ah, yes! You see, it's rather a funny story actually. It's...oh."

I instantly realized that the fact that Glimmer had invited me with some kind of hidden agenda behind it might sound a bit suspicious to Mermista. I stood there, staring, with my mouth halfway between open and close while I hoped for some way out of this.

The way came from my left, in the form of Catra. She made her presence known with that discreet cough that sounds a bit like a German Shepherd purring.

"Miss Greyskull. His lordship was keen to know whether you had brought your Tennis Racket and tennis outfit. I informed him that you had."

Up until that moment I had no idea that it had been packed, and I assumed it to be Catra who had anticipated its use.

"Why, yes! Thank you Catra! Well done! Right ho! That's why I'm here. To play tennis. Yes. What about you, Mista?"

"Tennis."

"You too!? Why, I didn't even know you were playing? We must…"

Mermista pinched the bridge of her nose. "Catra. You must be paid a darn fortune because I will never understand how you can put up with this one." She then turned to me, poked me in the chest and said growling, "Greyskull. The Gong will sound soon. We will go in. We will have a nice dinner. I will call upon you when I find it necessary. Please don't even breathe in my direction until then, I don't want my appetite spoiled."

She turned on her place and left with Sea Hawk in tow. We looked after them. Mista is rather rude when she is stressed, although I have to admit the difference is tiny.

"What ho, Catra?"

"Indeed, miss."

"Anyway! Catra, I…"

I was just about to inform Catra about the latest development, but then the second gong rang and Catra excused herself. I had nothing to do but to get inside, sit down, and eat. It was harder than expected, I must admit.

The caviar fraise and the Consomme aux Pommes d'Amour was easy to gobble down. But the Mignonette de Poulet Rotie petit duc along with the Timbale de ris de veau Toulousaine was already a harder nut to crack, and I barely managed to take seconds. And the dessert, L'Etoile au Berger and accompanying fruit plate was more or less left untouched after the first serving.

After that, however, there was a brief pause and a leg-stretcher before the coffee and brandy, and I seized the opportunity to rush out in the hallway to find Catra and inform her of Mermistas plans. Well, I did find Catra, but she wasn't alone. Glimmer was there as well.

"Adora! The woman of the hour! It is time to reveal my great plan."

"You're… great plan?"

"Yes! As I told you, you are not here primarily to parasite on Anatole's cooking and our clean sheets. You are here to help me. Well, I need Catra's help as well. We are going to steal my fathers prized clock."

Some might say that they should have seen that coming, but I must admit that I was surprised. Why in the world would Glimmer steal from her own father? Not that it's completely unheard of, she has more than once sneaked down to the kitchen to snitch cakes or maybe candy, but I have to say that the step from that to clocks would be a bit much, even for Glimmer. And then there was

the question of me helping Mermista steal the same clock. And me stealing the same clock as well. I might not be the brightest on the jewelry box, but I must say that a thing can only be stolen by one person at the time.

“Oh. Ehm. Well, actually old chum… I am in a bit of a stack right now… “

Glimmer placed her hand on my shoulder and gave me the biggest eyes she could muster. “Adora. Have you forgotten we went to school together?”

"Why, no, but…"

"Do you remember all the times I helped make your bed?"

"Yes, but…"

"And all those times I shared my chocolate bars with you?"

"Of course I do, but...

“And that time I helped you cheat on that latin test?"

“Yes, but… Now wait a second here, Glimmer!"

“And that time I told matron you had been in bed at 9 while you actually still were stuck in the well then.”

“Glimmer, I was locked into the washroom!”

“So? Point is, I was there for you. Now all I ask is for you to be there for me.”

It’s not that I didn’t want to help, it was just the growing feeling that this would end up with me in the tightest of tight spots between Glimmer, Aunt Sharon, Mista AND Lord Little-Gore.

“Well… um…”

“I will take that as a yes. I have secured Catra to take care of the alarm system. I will be on watch and YOU and Bow will acquire the clock.”

I could do nothing but lower my head. Glimmer snorted as she saw my hair.

“Huh. You’re still wearing your hair in a ponytail. Are you planning on going horse riding? Now?”

“I am not… It’s fashion!”

“Really? Hmm.”

A thought struck me. “What ho, Glimmer? Why is this clock so important for you? I mean I know that m...that they go for a good sum of money, but if you’re tight, I could perhaps lend you….”

“NO!” she exclaimed. “I mean… Thank you, Adora. But it’s not about that. We… just need it.”

“Need it? What for?”

Now it was her turn to look away. “Well... You see… there has been… some… things happening. A bit of a peril. And then a few more things. And Bow had… ehm..."

But then the second gong ran and Glimmer rushed away to the pool room. So there it was. I was being pulled into three different schemes. Mista’s, Glimmer’s and my own. This time, however, I managed to grab Catra before she disappeared.

"Catra! This is bad!"

"Really now miss? Was dinner unsatisfactory?"

"Forget dinner! You only know half of what’s stirring up this witches brew! It's Mermista AND Glimmer! Both want to steal the clock!"

"I see, miss."

"You ‘see’? Is that all you can say? You need to help me!"

"At the moment Miss, there is nothing I can do. My hands are tied. Ms. Little has, as you are well aware of, already asked for my help and it is not my position to decline a lady."

“What about me then?”

“You haven’t asked, miss.”

"Catra. Don't abandon me now. I am in a pit full of snakes AND Man Eating crows at the same time."

"I am dreadfully sorry Miss, but that is the truth. At the moment, there is nothing anyone of us can do. Imagine the scandal, miss, if Lady Little-Gore were to find out that her daughter was to steal the clock.”

I got a severe feeling of dread. “Look, Catra. If this is your plan to somehow frame ME for the crime so they can get away free, I am NOT going to participate."

She coughed discreetly. “I admit, miss, that I have taken the liberty to use you, who usually lacks the personal connection, as the so to speak “fall guy” at times, but I assure you, I had no idea what Miss Little had planned and I had no participation in the planning. I was as shocked as you, and indeed, all I could do was what was being asked of me.”

“Really.”

“Really, Miss. And even so, there is, as you say, the issue with your aunt."

I glared at her, hmpfd and turned on the spot. Still no help, hmm? Well, if that was how she would play it, I would go with double ponytails from now on! I returned to the coffee, my mind dark.

It began right after the brandy was served. We sat in the library. I noticed Sea-Hawk and Mermista leave the room, Mista giving me a 'come hither' gesture in my direction. I followed them out, excusing myself as I did.

"Greyskull. This is it."

"Is it? Blimey. Are you sure…"

"Yes. I am sure. Now…"

"Look, Mista. I know that we are old chums, sisters from other misters and all that, but I think this stealing business is a bit... wonky. I don't really think it is necessary to steal it, really."

She rolled her eyes. "What you think isn't important. It's what I think. And I KNOW that that clock needs to leave with me tonight. "

"Ah. Um. You see. I am not leaving tonight, I am staying the night. So, dreadfully sorry, Mista, but I can't steal it for you."

"Of course you can't. And you're not going to."

"Beg pardon?"

"You're not going to steal it. Your honesty and frankly speaking complete inability to fool someone is useless in this game."

I stared at her. "So… what do you want me to do?"

"Go back in there, be your usual clueless self and make sure no one comes out in the hallway."

"Well, that should be easy enough!"

"Your confidence creeps me out. Don't. Mess. This. Up." She emphasized every word by poking me right between my step collars. And then she went back into the library, leaving me alone with my thoughts in the hallway. They were a rather gloomy

company. I waited for a few minutes, hoping that a miracle in the form of Catra would show up. When she didn't, I sighed and went for my execution.

I wandered back into the room, trying my best to look casual and chose-free as they come. I put on my best nonchalant smile and eyed the room. I instantly wished there had been a few more people around, because save for the servants, there was just me, Glimmer, Bow, Mista, Lady Little-Gore and Lord Little-Gore. Glimmer and her mother were standing around the fireplace, and considering the annoyed look on Glimmer's face the conversation was about marriage. That subject always gives me a cold chill and I found the subconscious need before I did anything else to first grab myself a cocktail. Now, I want to state clearly , that it is not the proposition of marriage that scares me, but that people have a tendency to set me up with others completely and utterly unsuitable for me. If I get the possibility to marry, I want to choose myself. A Greyskull has to have standards.

I saw Bow and Mista chatting, but as I looked their way, Mermista VERY distinctively turned her back to me. It annoyed me fiercely and I decided to stroll over to see what her business was. When she saw it, she took a paper, wrote something on it and had one of the servants to hand it to me.

In Mistas messy writing it said

Stay away. I frowned, and wrote on the other side.

What ho? She took a new piece of paper and had the same discreet servant deliver it.

Stay away I said. This was strange indeed.

What for? The server seemed to have resignated and was simply standing in wait for the next note.

I don't want to talk with you.

Come now, Have I done anything to upset you?

Adora...

No, really! If I have upset you, I want to know. She had to take a whole new note for this. I also saw her pinch the bridge of her nose as Bow looked interested.

I don't want to raise any suspicion you imbecile. I take care of distracting Arrows, you do his lordship.

Finally the coin slipped into place. I gave her a thumbs up and strolled over to try the old Greyskull charm on his Lordship. He and I aren't on a first name basis, but we have a few common interests. If nothing, we can always talk about cricket.

I made myself another cocktail, a simple whiskey and Soda this time, and strolled over to him.

"Hullo Hullo hullo!"

"Ah! Miss Greyskull! What a world it is, aye?"

"Ah yes. Well, honestly, it looks like pretty much the same world since last time I checked really."

He laughed. "Good one, miss Greyskull. Good one. A sense of humour is essential to keep a level head in these times. Tell me your secret, Miss Greyskull. Business these days… business any days! Ah, my rivals are like hawks. Show any weakness and they will hack you to pieces! I tell you, it is definitely not cricket!"

I found my opening. "Speaking about Cricket, " I said, "Did you happen to read…"

"I am trying my best to get my baby prepared for the world she will face the day I can no longer protect her. I have given her the best education and the best funds. But you know what's most important? Companionship!"

"Oh really? That is interesting! Because, well, now, you see, in the latest game between Leicester and..."

"Miss Greyskull. Let me be frank with you. You're not getting younger."

The turn this conversation just took wasn't what I expected. "Eh, no I suppose."

"Oh, I know it's not polite to remind the youth of the inevitable. My old man kept nagging me about 'growing up' and 'be responsible'. Well, things turned out well enough for me."

"Oh yes! Yes indeed."

"But let's go straight to business. " He paused, giving a happy and contemptuous eye to his daughter and demi-soninlaw. He took a sip from his drink, then he looked at me again. "Have you considered marriage, miss Greyskull?"

I have to say, his proposal shocked me. I may not have made the most comprehensive impression at that moment. "Well, um…" I said. "I am flattered of course, but… well you see… I am not really looking right now and… well.. You are married to Lady Little and…"

He stared at me, then he began to laugh. "That's what I like about you, Grayskull! Your hilarious sense of humour! He he… not that I wouldn't mind marrying a young, prime example of a woman -had I not been VERY VERY HAPPY!" he added slightly too loud, " But I meant whether you had considered marrying someone your age?"

"Ah. Um… well… You see…"

"You know Bertram? My daughter's fiancee?"

"Bow! Oh yes, of course. "

"A good looking fella. Bit of a weakling, but pleasant and submissive enough for my little Glimmer. But have you met anyone of his brothers?"

I had not, but Bow had mentioned several times himself being the youngest of a whole cohort of brothers.

"Fine, strong young men, all of them. Roderick, for example. Captain in the navy. Patrick. Runs a big farm in America. All of them good men who need a strong young woman like you to make sure the bloodline stays strong!"

The subject was not new to me, in fact, it was Aunt Sharon's third favourite subject (after her own excellence and Catra's attitude) and I reacted as I usually did. I blushed tremendously and my throat got dry as the wine cellar at the bishop of east Anglia.

"I know that the head isn't maybe the most prominent feature on you, Greyskull. But you look good enough, wide hips and a strong chest! And in all honesty, you don't procreate with your head, right? I assure you I didn't" He laughed heartily at his own joke.

"Welll…"

Luckily I didn't have to reply because in that very moment I spotted Sea Hawk in the doorway. He was waving vigorously and winked at me with the right eye. Then he slipped behind the wall, only to show up again, peeking into the room. Then his head disappeared again only to show up a few seconds later.

"What is that man doing? Is that… the young seaman? A friend of yours, Greyskull?"

"Just an acquaintance… I will go and talk to him." I excused myself and went out to see what the fellow wanted.

"Adora!" He whispered. Sea Hawk-whispered, that is. "You were supposed to keep his lordship busy!"

"I was! What on earth were you doing?"

"I was being sneaky!"

I blinked. "Sneaky? Well, you could've fooled me. You were waving and making rather a mess, actually."

"Of course! You can't be sneaky unless someone first notices you, then DOESN'T notice you."

I admit that I am not the world's most brainy chap, but even I had to admit that this was insanity.

"Sea Hawk. Everyone in the room saw you."

“Really? Damn.” And then he turned, and ran away. I stared after him.

“Peculiar man, that one. But, old Anastassakis is peculiar himself, no surprise that his daughter takes after him.” It was Lord Little-Gore that had snuck up next to me and almost made me wet myself.

“Are you inspecting my clock, Greyskull? It’s something alright!" He paused. "Greyskull… You are not here on any funny business, are you?"

"What? Why, no! No, I assure you!"

"Weell, I might as well believe you. Saucepans in silver is well alright you know but this!" He knocked on the clock with his knuckle. "This, is something else. It's an original Henson, Benson and Swanson! I had it checked alright! Have you heard about them?”

I decided that being open and honest yet tactful was the best approach. "Apparently they were a bunch of loonies.”

“Indeed, so they say. No matter, it is an antique now! Interestly enough, I have no memory of purchasing it. Found it a month ago when Angella cleaned out the attic in Glimmers old rooms. Bah, doesn't matter. If it’s worth a fortune, I am not complaining about memories. It’s a darn fine piece of goods.” He turned around. "Ah, I could talk about my collection for hours, but there is a glass of

brandy with my name on back in the library. By the way, Grayskull… I had a new alarm system installed last month and I included the clock the minute I found it. You wouldn't have gotten away with it anyway."

I decided that I'd better be quiet.

Half an hour later, I met Mista in the hallway. She was fully dressed and ready to leave. A huge hulk of a woman walked behind her, carrying her bags. Huntara obviously. I wouldn't mind trying my luck against her in the ring, actually. But that was hardly a subject for now. Mista didn't look up for it. Still, I had to be conversational.

"So, Mista. Leaving the crime scene early?"

"Shut up, Adora."

"I say, too bad Sea Hawk didn't make it. Really awful, really."

"I said SHUT UP."

"Okay, okay. I will shut the old bread basket."

"Good." Then she turned to Huntara. "Is the car ready?"

"Yes, ma'm."

"And the engine is running in case we need to make a hasty retreat?"

"Yes ma'm."

"Good. Well, Good night Adora. I hope."

And then she left. Suddenly Bow stood beside me. "So, Adora. What are you up to?"

"Nothing, I suppose. Probably heading to bed. This day is getting on me. This business with the clock is wrecking the old Greyskull nerves."

“Are they? How?”

Darn it. I almost managed to give away the whole of Mermistas plan. I had to shift the subject and that fast. “Say, Bow, did you happen to read the results for Leicester in their latest match? I…”

“Adora. It’s me. You don’t have to pretend, I am in on the plot.”

I got all cold.“ARE YOU? When did she tell you?”

“...Pretty much from the beginning? Considering that I was...um…”

Now I must admit, I didn’t follow this at all. “You were there from the beginning? Where you at Sea Gate the day that Sea Hawk… You know?”

“Eeeeh… No?”

“Then what do you mean that you were there from the beginning? Because Miiiiiiaaahhh… YOU are referring to when GLIMMER told you!” Finally the stone fell into my head.

“Yes…? Who else? Adora, do you know something I don’t?”

“No! No no no. I was just… Just… Nerves, I told you, right? So, you heard about what Sea Hawk did then?”

“Yes, I did. It was...not pleasant.”

“Why not?”

“I...um… I was there… about one month earlier and...I ...Like the clock? Nice design? You know? My mentor would love it, I thought. Sad to see it go. Aaand speaking about my mentor… Adora… You see, my mentor has this really interesting contraption and if you could just spare 25 pounds, you would…"

I zoned out. Bow is considering himself a bit of a handy man and he has this strange 'mentor' with whom he scholars himself.

Wacky Lucy or whatever she is called is always coming up with all kinds of weird mechanisms, and most of the time they're useless. Most of the time it costs a few hundred pounds to find out, and most of the time I have paid for it. Catra always advises me not to, and I was going to decline again when I realized something.

Mista had said something about if they should have the need for a hasty retreat. They planned another attempt! And then I remembered...the alarm!

"Bow!" I interrupted him. "We have to…" the next moment the sound of a claxon echoed in the house. I immediately knew what had happened and we ran for the clock. I was prepared for a broken clock and a running Sea Hawk, but there was nothing. The clock was intact. But as I stood there, I heard a voice. "Greyskull! I knew it! Couldn't keep your fingers off my property, aye? And here I believed you to be a proper wife to my friends sons! You… you…" Bow did his best to explain that he had been with me, but Lord Little-Gore wasn't a keen listener on that kind of tune.

"Criminal! What do you have to say for yourself?"

"Well." I said. "You see…" I said. "It's actually rather funny…" I said. I had no idea what to say. I couldn't give away Mistas husband. She would never forgive me. Even if she thinks he's wackier than a whack during summer, he is still her whack.

Luckily in the next moment I heard another scream. "The western folly is on fire!" That took away some of the attention from me, and we ran outside.

The little folly was indeed on fire. Lord Little-Gore stared at it, then at me. "You MANIAC! This is all your plan, isn't it? I will…"

He prepared himself for a blow. Well, he did hit me, but his reaction was "OW OW OW OW OW!" and then he fainted. We carried him inside. Lady Little-Gore asked what had happened.

"He tried to knock Adora out, " Bow explained. Angella sighed.

"Micah, you old fool… Can you please take him to his room? I will call the doctor. And then… let's go to bed. This evening has been eventful enough.

Well, as I say, no good talking back to a lady. I was barely in my pajamas when I collapsed on the pillow.

The morning began as usual, Catra woke me up with tea and a morning report.

"Why, good morning, Catra!"

"Good morning, Miss."

"Slept well?"

"Well enough considering the circumstances, miss. Milk and sugar?"

"Yes and thank you! So, how's the land for Greyskulls, hmm, Catra? Yesterday my stocks were rather low, I say."

"So I heard, miss. I however managed to get a word with his Lordship and her ladyship just before I got here. We had a very enlightening conversation. I gave evidence that you had been observed far away from both the clock and the fire, meaning that you couldn't be involved." She served me the cup. "I might also have mentioned seeing a dark figure in the hallway earlier before the alarm rang."

"Ah! Sea Hawk had donned a disguise then?"

"Most probably, Miss."

"Well thank goodness for you!" I drank. A good cup of tea does WONDER for the stability of the mind! "So, act I have concluded. The clock is still in place, Mista hasn't got her hands on it and I am clear of suspicion. "

"Yes miss."

"Too bad I might have to steal it anyway."

"Indeed miss."

I decided to simply forget all my troubles until a later point. It was a new and blank day and it was time for the best meal of said day. No reason not to be positive. "Ah well! That's life I guess." I said, heartily." Breakfast is served?"

"It is, Miss. Ah, and perhaps you want to dress suitably for Tennis? His lordship wanted to have a set with you as an apology."

I accepted his Lordship's somewhat embarrassed apology and over the old H & E we became chums and brothers. The tennis game was a surprisingly active affair, I have to give it to him, he was much faster and more agile than I had anticipated. I still won, of course. But it did break a sweat, and I decided to call off my pre-lunch jog.

As I made myself over to the library for a chance to find yesterday's "Times" I passed the place where the damn clock stood and I couldn't help sighing. I was out of the ashes for now, but the fire was not over poured by water just yet. Catra had at least finally shown the old spirit and had cleared me. I was so deep down in my gratitude for Catra that I didn't notice that I couldn't see the clock. I looked again. The place on the wall where it had stood was severely lacking a clock.

I checked twice, then I ran to find Catra.

“Catra!” I exclaimed, “The cl…” It suddenly struck me that I should probably NOT announce the disappearance of the clock to

the whole estate, especially not after being accused of stealing it and then after some queer turns being cleared from suspicion. Especially not since Catra was in conversation with Lady Little-Gore. They both turned their heads towards me, however, I felt that right now I was not prepared to have a conversation with her. I turned and said "...cl...clutch! On my handkerchief! Is broken! I… need you to fix that.! But not now, when you have time and NOT in conversation with Glimmer's mo...LADY Little-Gore! I'll be in my room! And what ho! Jolly good to see you, your ladyship."

I did in fact not run up to my room as I found the route blocked by Bow, Glimmer and Lord Little-Gore. Now, I found myself in the pressure spot as they say. I could hardly go back, causing Lady Little-Gore to ask why I left in such a hurry only to return with the same speed. And I could not go up to Glimmer and Co. with a smile on my face and a "I say! What a lovely day it is!" on my lips, when it was 1. In fact rather cloudy and 2. They had already seen me often enough for that greeting to be redundant.

In the end, the situation was resolved by Glimmer, who shouted "Adora! Stop looking like you just had a fish fly out of your mouth and get over here!"

"Oh! Why, yes! Glimmer."

I walked over, Glimmer and Bow giving me some kind of knowing look, where I had the distinct idea that they expected me to know something I absolutely didn't, while his Lordship looked at me from top to bottom and up again with a small smile. "My my, you do look like you have seen a ghost!" He followed up his comment with giving me a hearty slap on my back."I didn't push you too hard, did I? You're someone who could take some real heat, anyway, huh, Greyskull?"

"Oh! He he, no sir! It has to be a lot warmer for me to pass out." Glimmer frowned and Bow kept that worried glance, but his Lordship did not notice anything, he laughed.

"Ah, ha ha! That's the spirit, Greyskull! You really need to come by more often! I could use a good laugh and you could use the exercise!"

"Oh! Why, yes! He he. Sounds splendid to me! Splendid, splendid indeed!"

"SO, ADORA!" Glimmer butted in. "We were talking about how you really can't stay much longer and that we need to leave tonight."

"I can't?"

"No, Adora." Bow spoke. "You have your very important boxing practice tomorrow. Which you absolutely can't miss, can you?"

"My what?"

"Your BOXING!" Glimmer laid weight on every syllable, which made it even more confusing. Did she assume me to be deaf? "The one you told me you had started with on mondays. The one that was so important!"

I can't deny it, I was confused. Glimmer very rarely engaged in my exercise routines so I felt the necessity to clear things up a bit.

"Now, Glimmer, I think you have misunderstood a thing or two. You see, Mondays are my weight lifting days. You see, it's important to start the week with preparing all your muscles in the most…"

"ADORA!" Glimmer was almost red in her face now. Again I felt there being something I was supposed to know that I didn't fathom.

"Yes?"

She was about to continue when his Lordship placed a hand on her shoulder. "Now now, my girl! I think you should listen to Miss Greyskull. That is some really interesting things you're saying!

Perhaps you can give my girl one or two suggestions? Love handles aren't exactly flattering on a woman, especially not a young girl in the spring of her life!"

I brightened up noticeably. It isn't often that I get praise, so I always lick it up as much as I can. Also, I have been on this subject with Glimmer more than once. Not that I consider her fat or anything, but everyone could use some exercise now and then! Sound mind in a sound body, you know!

"Why, yes! But actually, Glimmer, for you I wouldn't suggest something as rough as weightlifting as a start. Perhaps swimming, or just a simple walk every day would be more suitable. I…"

While his Lordship looked at me with genuine interest, Bow made a face and a gesture that seemed to me like he wanted me to stop talking. And Glimmer looked like she had eaten a glowing poker.

"Glimmer? Is something bothering you?"

I saw her biting her lip, and then she said in a cheerful voice that I never heard her use before: "Daddy? Could you please show Bertram your collection of old watches? You know how much he likes old tech?"

His Lordship looked up at Glimmer with surprise, then he looked at Bow who also looked surprised, but smiled and said: "Yes! Actually your lordship, I Have heard so much about it! Let's leave the ladies to themselves, shall we?"

His Lordship wasn't hard to persuade and soon I was alone with Glimmer.

"So, old girl! About your training…"

"Adora. Shut up."

"I will shut up."

"1. Never. NEVER. talk to me about if I need exercise or not again, especially NOT in front of Daddy."

"Really? Why, you seemed…"

"ADORA! CAN YOU… stop being so much YOU and use that brain that MUST be somewhere inside? Now. 2. I… you know what, I am too upset to talk to you. I swear, hadn't it been for the fact that we went to school together and I know that you are a human version of a Labrador, I would never talk to you again.

"Now, really, Glimmer. That's a bit harsh."

"Really?"

"Yes. Golden Retriever, that is what Catra says I act like."

"...Go to your room. Let Catra deal with you, I don't… I just can't...just try to remember, you have to leave tonight! Understand?!"

"Bang on, old gal!"

She shook her head. "I should just have brought Scorpia and be done with it but she's just the same…"

I was alone. I didn't hesitate, I ran up the stairs to my rooms, thereby passing the non existing clock again, until I finally got to shut the door behind me.

"Phew! That was a doozy!"

"Indeed, miss."

I swung round, almost colliding with Catra. "How did you get in?"

"I was right behind you, Miss. You look a bit weary, do you perhaps require a drink?"

"No! Or, well, yes. Or… I don't know! Catra! Glimmer is…" But then I realized the most important issue, us leaving could wait. "We

need to be quick! The clock is gone! Stolen!"

"Really, miss?"

"Really! I just passed the damn thing in question and it wasn't there."

"I see, miss."

"Catra. We need to tell his Lordship. "

She coughed. "I don't think that is the best way of proceeding, miss."

"Oh? Why?"

"I do know a bit about the whereabouts of the clock, miss. I also know who took it and at the moment it's probably for the best to not break status quo."

"Ah, to the woods with your Latin quotes, Catra! Why isn't it a good thing to tell Lord Little-Gore? And why do YOU know about the theft?"

"Because, miss, even if I can't say I am proud of it, I was partaking in the theft. I took care of the alarm as was my orders."

"Orders…" The realization hit me like a tomato on a music hall stage. "Orders! You mean that Glimmer actually pulled through with her attempt?"

"She did indeed, miss."

"But… but I was supposed to help her!"

"Yes, I believe you were, miss."

"But… She didn't tell me!"

"You were busy playing tennis with his Lordship, miss. I may have suggested to miss Little that it was better for you to be the

distraction. It happens to occur at the same time as her Ladyship was out in the garden looking after her roses and it seemd to be appropriate to act."

"So, the coast was clear then."

"As you say, miss."

I had to lay down and draw a few breaths. "Alright. So they took the clock. No problem. As long as her old folks doesn't notice there shouldn't be a problem. I assume it was a bit of a stretch, right? It looked rather heavy and I guess I was supposed to be the one carrying it."

"Indeed it was Miss. You were greatly missed by us all. We did our best, but we could only carry it so far."

I stared at Catra. She looked at me with an almost expressionless face, safe for the shadow of a snide smile. I suddenly felt a cold chill down my spine, and it was only in part caused by my realization of what Glimmer actually wanted to tell me and how greatly I insulted her… I turned my head to the darkest part of my room. And there it was, looking at me like the grim reaper. (It was probably just the shadows, but still!). I jumped out of bed and pointed at it, with my mouth open. Again, Catra coughed. "As I said, we couldn't carry it very far. I suggested your room as a temporary hiding spot."

I still pointed and stared. I suppose I gave a good impression of a bird house.

"Perhaps I should get you something to drink, Miss?"

I nodded. However, before she could leave, there was a knock on the door and the booming voice of Lord Little-Gore was heard through the wood.

"Greyskull? You in there? You looked so pale before, and Glimmer just rushed by looking like a tickled bull, so I just wanted to know if you were still standing?"

End of part 3

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Again there was a knock, and another call.

"Greyskull! Open up!"

The door was not locked. I hoped that his Lordship had the decency not to enter without permission. However, he did strike me as some who might see himself above that…

"Do not worry, your Lordship! I am perfectly fine!"

"Jolly good! I guess you don't mind if I come in then!?"

"No! No! Stay outside! I mean… I...um…"

"Greyskull? Are you sure something's not the matter? You sound a bit off."

"Oh! No, no. I am fine. Just fine. He he. Finer than a fine! But… Um… I…."

I looked around the room frantically in search for a solution. I found Catra, who gestured something at me. She had her hands in chest height and mimicked pulling her hands apart.

"I… am… currently… (what on earth was she doing!?) Showing you my...No, sorry… it wasn't that… um…" Catra made a face and started to unbutton her shirt.

"Catra!" I hissed, "you can't undress now! His…" then I understood. "I am undress...I am… I am changing my clothes! Yes! That's what I am doing. Changing. Yes."

"Oh! I see. You young ladies… Why are you changing?"

"Isn't that a bit of a personal question, your Lordship?"

"Oh! Well… I was just… You looked fine just now so… I wonder if there had been some problem."

"Oh! Yes! I see! That is very thoughtful of you, your Lordship."

There was a pause. "Miss Greyskull, you sound rather upset. Please tell me when you're done changing, I want to see for myself that everything is alright with you."

"I say! Very considerate of you, but I assure you that it is not necessary."

"Let me be the judge of that, miss!"

At school we had this matron. Well, actually, we had two. Both were peculiar in their own very way. One always called me by my cousins name, but this was not her. She was always kind. Hope was… peculiar. She was the one who took care of us most of the time. I should probably be brief since I was in a bit of a jiffy with his Lordship outside the door. Anyways, she usually called us with first names, since she had read that that gave her a special contact with the children. So she always called me Adora but if she switched to *miss* or *Miss Greyskull!* I knew that she had discovered the cookie theft. Which was incredibly unfair, since it usually was Glimmer who did it.

"Catra!" I hissed "He *miss-es* me!"

"So I hear, miss."

"What shall we do?"

"You are using the light green cotton skirt, miss?"

"Well, you should know! You're the one who picked it out! I mean, yes! Yes I do!" I added, when I saw a frown play on Catras lips. But it was gone soon enough. She nodded, and walked over to the door.

"Ehrm. Lord Little-Gore. I am afraid that Miss Greyskull are stuck in a bit of a… wardrobe malfunction. A zipper that is stuck."

"So? It's not a big deal!"

"I am afraid it's placed in a bit of a… sensitive area. You have to excuse her, she find this extremely embarrassing. "

There was a silence. And then "OH! OH! AHA! ...I am dreadfully sorry, Greyskull. Do take your time."

And then there was nothing but silence. I think he left.

"Phew. That was indeed something else."

"Indeed it was, miss. Now, you have to take of your clothes.

"CATRA! WHAT HO?"

She cleared her throat but she didn't blush. She looked me straight in the eyes. "His Lordship may not be as bright, but he takes notice on a good looking lady's outfit. He is in that age, nothing personal, miss. He will notice if you haven't changed clothes for tea."

"By jove Catra! You are right! But what should I wear?"

She opened the suitcase. "I have a few suggestions… Miss Greyskull."

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It must have been because of her dislike of the ponytail. The woman had the audacity to suggest my riding outfit! Pants, boots, shirt, red vest… She must have packed it to mock me! Well, never let it be said that a Greyskull will back down from a challenge! I wore the ponytail, I was in charge! So that was what I wore for tea.

His Lordship must have been truly taken aback from the situation at the door. He only glanced at me from time to time and barely spoke to me, although I tried. It was instead Lady Little-Gore that conversated with me. Well, she is pleasant so I didn't mind.

"You are indeed a woman with much more depth than I expected, miss Greyskull." She said with an amused look at her husband. "It is very rarely I see him completely stunned like that."

"Oh! I say, that is… very kind of you. Most people just comment on my length. "

She laughed. She had a very nice laugh. Pearly. "You are indeed as amusing as they say. Oh, by the way, you don't happen to play rugby, do you?"

I shone up. "As the matter of fact, I do! Your ladyship! Actually, I have a game on Tuesday. Well, we have. My team. Not me and Catra. Even if she will come and watch. Me. Playing."

She smiled. "Interesting. We have a local game here, it's an old tradition. The two nearby villages meet on the field nearby. It's a few months away. Perhaps you would like to come and see that?"

"Well," I said, "it depends. If I am busy or not. You see, on Wednesday's there's fencing. On Tuesdays there's my regular Rugby. On Fridays there's polo and on Thursdays… Thursdays I am actually free! "

She smiled again. "How delightful. Let's hope the game is on a Thursday then."

The conversation went on, but I once or twice shot his Lordship a look. Darn! He was red as a carrot! Maybe something with his heart? I mentioned this to her Ladyship but Ladyship waved it off. "I will take care of that tonight" she said with a smile. She also asked if I could perhaps introduce her to the game of tennis. I said I'd be delighted, and we agreed to meet at five. Apparently Catra had a spare set of clothes she could borrow. That woman is prepared for EVERYTHING!

***

It was sometime after tea that Glimmer gathered us all in the still remaining bigger folly. The smaller one was nothing but ashes. I got to give it to Sea Hawk, when he burns something down, he burns it completely.

Anyway, all of us was me, Bow, Catra and Glimmer herself.

"So." She begun. "Before we start, this…" she produced a staff with a four-point star surrounded by a circle that bore a particular likeness to a crescent moon, "this is the Brightmoon ceremonial staff. It's my father's, he uses it when they meet with the Free Masons here. But today, it's the talking staff. It's only the one that holds the staff, and ONLY HER, that is allowed to speak."

I opened my mouth to protest, then I realized that I wasn't allowed, and just shot Glimmer a 'what now'-look. Bow nodded and Catra rolled her eyes. But she followed it up with a nod as well.

"So. The clock. It stands in Adora's room. It needs to be moved from there. We need to make sure that we do it soon and without anyone suspecting that we did it. Everyone got that?"

We nodded.

"Now, since Adora completely wrecked my original plan by accepting Mommy's proposal for teaching her tennis, I can't put the blame for the theft on her." I stood up, pointing at her, mouth open. Catra however, cleared her throat. I sat down again.

"Shut it, Adora. You messed up my plan AND called me fat -yes you did- in front of Daddy. Take it like a Greyskull or whatever you always say. Nice handling of Daddy afterwards though, but that's beside the point! Now, I had the idea that we could blame Sea Hawk, but Mermista has exclusive rights for him as a scapegoat. That means we have to go the other way. An Alibi "

I raised a finger.

"Oh come on, Adora! You know what an alibi is!"

Catra cleared her throat and took the staff. "I believe that what Miss Greyskull wanted to focus your attention on, is that you will need not one, but several alibis. Since Master Bertram and Miss Greyskull are the ones most capable of moving the clock from the room, they need to be provided first. However, they can't leave the estate without catching too much attention, meaning that they have to move it around the estate. Which reminds me, later on, the clock can't be associated with leaving the estate with Miss Greyskull."

Glimmer took the staff back. "Oh yeah? And why not?" She returned the staff to Catra.

"Our car is too small, Miss Little. There is no place for it."

"Oh." Glimmer seemed to forget the rule of the staff. I opened my mouth.

"You are still not allowed to speak, Adora."

I closed it. Catra opened hers and proceeded to speak. Cheeky devil.

"If I may suggest, Miss Little, if Miss Greyskull were to withdraw early, after dinner, she and master Bertram could use the time when all the servants are busy cleaning up, to move the clock to a neutral ground on the estate. I can provide an alibi for Miss Greyskull during that time and I am sure you can create something equally suitable for Master Bertram."

Here Glimmer blushed. Bow gave her an eye and then he blushed too. I didn't ask, I wasn't allowed anyway.

"Yes, that was exactly what I was going to say." Glimmer spoke after collecting herself. "Hide the clock in the old gardener's shed. Not the new one, the old one. It's big enough. Daddy always has a nightcap on Saturdays and he likes to have company so we can get together then. Then we cook up some reason for us to leave

after that, making sure everyone knows that we are leaving and Adora is still here. Then we return by the protection of darkness to the east gate with the car. You and Bow go and fetch it and bring it to the car."

I could swear I saw the shadow of a smile on Catra.

"Now, the old shed is outside the backdoor entrance next to the east wing stairs. It's a 56-yards walk from your room. It takes one minute to walk to the stairs, the corner keeping you out of sight of Juliet. The left stairs are marble, they don't creek, but be sure to use rubber shoes so you won't create noice. Go one step at the time. This is the most critical moment, which needs to be timed immaculately. Old Morden passes by carrying trash. When you hear her pass, count to ten and start walking. Once you're down, turn right and hide in the alcove. It's big enough. Wait for her to return, then it's 24 yards to the door. It doesn't creek. There you hide in the bushes outside the door to make sure that noone sees you. After that it's just along the ivy alley to the shed. And you're done."

We all stared at Glimmer.

"What? It works!"

We kept staring.

"...Bow used to have that as his room, okay? ...I may have… ehrm…" Bow blushed again. I smiled. How thoughtful of Glimmer to have a sneak way!

"Ah yes. May I ask where Master Bertrams room is now?" Catra.

"Third floor in the middle wing, just next to the food and wash elevator." She paused. "So much more Swift." She smiled. "Why do you want to know that?"

"Ah. I was just thinking if we might be in need of a backup plan and a second hiding place in case of an emergency." I know Catra

and that was not why she asked. I still wasn't allowed to speak, though.

"Good thinking Catra, but it shouldn't be necessary. "

"Very well, Miss Little."

"Alright! So, dinner! And a quick rendezvous afterwards. Bow, be at Adoras room at thirty past eight."

He nodded. But I felt a need to put my foot down! Adora S. Greyskull was not just a pair of strong arms! I took the staff.

"Adora?"

"I have the talking staff now! It's my turn to talk!"

"Good! And now you did. Well done Adora."

She took the staff and then they left, both separate ways. Catra stayed with me and escorted me to my room. But I say! Glimmer can be so far-sighted! I was a bit upset, and I didn't even bother to change clothes. Dinner was a simple affair tonight, since we were fewer guests, but that didn't stop the Neige aux Perles des Alpes or Indeed the Pointes d’asperges a la Mistinguette to be absolutely délicieuse and it got me back into good spirits again. I didn't say much, though. I excused myself after but one brandy, saying I had slept rather badly the night before. An obvious lie, but as Catra puts it "probably the singular one you can pull off, miss."

I met with Catra and she helped me change into my outfit for shady business. (Actually my skiing wear, save for the coat and gloves. Very soft and smooth. I have no idea why she packed it though.)

At the estimated time Catra opened the door and let in Bow. How she heard him I will never understand. I had moved the clock to the wall next to the door so it was just to grab it and go.

We followed Glimmer's plan. It was surprisingly solid, considering it was, well, Glimmer's plan. You see, the old gal has a great heart, but doesn't plan very well. It was a bit of a hitch to get it down the stairs, but the old Greyskull muscles showed what they were made of. Muscles.

But as we closed the shed behind us, a thought struck me. "Say, Bow! I never saw you talking to Sea Hawk yesterday! A bit if a knot on the old telephone line behind you?"

"What? No, no no. I just… We never spoke, that was just it."

"Oh. Well, I imagine the two of you being rather fond of each other? Did you have a fall out? I don't remember hearing that you were there when… I mean, at the last time Sea Sea Hawk arranged a dinner?"

"Oh. Well, no, I wasn't. Not that time. I was invited but I declined. I… had to… do… stuff. BUT I was there the first time he arranged a dinner. Or a "Shindig" as he called it. It was… interesting."

I nodded. I could only imagine. We went separate ways, I had my alibi to give me a jacket and then we went down for the night cap. It was short, but pleasant. Glimmer had already told her parents of their hasty leave and in the end it was nothing but a small sherry and good night.

Well, not for me, though. Back to the room and dress up again, and wait. I must admit, I was nervous. Catra was there, but she was busting herself with an edifying book, and I didn't want to disturb her. I just let it the occasional "I say!" Or "Blimey!" To cool down.

Finally there was a brief knock on my window. A stone had been thrown. I looked out to see Bow waiting for me.

"Well" I said. "Showtime."

"Yes miss."

"Well… Tata for now then, Catra."

I was still nervous. But before I left, Catra made some minor adjustments to my outfit and leaned in. "It will go well, Miss Greyskull. I believe in you."

It is perhaps strange, but that encouragement was all I needed and I flew down the stairs towards the shed. There I met with an equally dressed in black clothing-Bow who even sported a small domino-mask.

"What ho?" I whispered.

"So that no one will recognize me."

"But Bow, this is Brightmoon. Doesn't everyone know you?"

"Well, yeah… but with a mask, I can claim that I am my brother."

"Ah. Smart!"

And so, we began the carrying. Glimmer had been rather vague on the way we should take on the outside; apparently her need to sneak in and out was limited to the perimeter of the estate itself and not the surroundings. We were halfway down the path of the yew alley before Bow realized we were going in the opposite direction.

"Wouldn't it have been easier to just go back the way you came, Bow?"

"Yes, but I thought that perhaps it would be wise to confuse any potential followers."

"Good thinking!"

We managed to sneak unspotted all the way around the estate to the opposite side and was now carrying our loot through the animal garden. It has that name Because Her ladyship has the bushes and trees trimmed in the shapes of different animals.

I had only seen it briefly, since the tennis court was in the other part of the estate, but I had heard that there was one figure of a horsez which apparently bore a significant likeness to Swiftwind!

"Adora! Watch where you're going!"

"I am, bow! I just wanted to…"

"Stop wanting, and keep walking! This is the most critical part!"

"No worries, Bow! I don't see or hear any…"

Suddenly I heard footsteps coming our direction. I acted on pure instinct, I pushed the clock and Bow right into the closest shrubbery. Unfortunately, the push had made me lose my balance and I fell, face forward onto the ground. The question of how to explain why I was lying on the ground at almost 11 o'clock at night depended very much on the person coming. As I saw the approaching figure to br Lord Little-Gore, I did the only thing I could think of. I started to do push-ups. He stopped a few feet away from me, looked at me for a moment while he smoked his cigar. Then he spoke. "I am afraid, Miss Greyskull, that your Cavalier has left you." I could hear his laughter long and well after he had turned the corner.

As soon as he had passed, I pulled Bow and then the clock from the shrubbery, which I only now noticed was the one in the shape of a horse.

"I say, Bow. It actually looks a little bit like Swift wind!"

It was like I could hear a faint neigh in the distance.

"Could you stop observing the garden and help me with this, Adora?"

"Oh! Yes, yes indeed!"

The rest was remarkably easy, we didn't get disturbed again. And after a quick hurl, the clock was loaded into Glimmer and Bows

station wagon.

"Well, that was it!"

"Thank you so much, Adora. I forgive you for calling me fat!"

"Oh, that was nothing old Gal! I'd do it again in a jiffy! ...I mean… this… and not…"

Glimmer smiled and walked up to me. She hugged me and gave me two sisterly kisses on both cheeks. "Never change, Adora. Never change, you beautiful idiot."

"Um… Thanks?"

Bow cleared his throat. "Um...Maybe it's better if we try to avoid each other for a while now? Just to… make sure no one gets suspicious."

"That might be for the best! Well, see you in a few days then!"

"Weeks, actually. We have decided to take a little vacation. It's… well, you know."

I actually didn't, but I was beginning to feel rather tired and the evening had been eventful enough for me.

"Well, have a good trip then! And good luck with the clock. Oh, I forgot to ask, where are you taking it?"

They glanced at each other. "Have you actually started to be cautious, Adora?"

"What? Well, maybe, I suppose. But I am mostly curious, that is all."

"The less you know the better, Adora."

I frowned. "Oh come on! You said you had forgiven me!"

Glimmer smiled uneasy. "You… will know. Soon. I promise… Oh, and here!" She produced a 10 Bob note. "Give it to Catra and thank her from me."

"I will". But in my heart I knew that moment wouldn't be soon. From what I had seen, Catra hadn't deserved it. I said good night and after that I welcomed the bed with open arms. Well, not before changing out of my outlaw outfit. But you get the gist of it.

The morning after, me and Catra took a hearty farewell to the estate and its inhabitants after breakfast. Once again, the old H and E and a strong cup of tea made me a new Adora again. I was in an excellent mood and since it was Sunday, I had Catra drop me off at the Plumeria stables. I felt that the successful conclusion of the weekend deserved a celebration. Perfuma was out but the stable staff was in place and ready to help me. And Swift Wind was more than happy to join in on the festivities. We were out for over two hours and it was way past lunch when I finally was back in London to walk over the threshold of the old lair. The smell of food hit me like a pleasant brick in the face.

"I say, Catra! It smells delicious! Like ointment on a weary soul. What is that quote now again, 'let lunch be the cure and dinner…"

"Let food be thy medicine and medicine be thy food, miss. It's Hippocrates."

"Well, Hip hip hooray then! However, I sure hope you're serving something other than a wonder cure for measles for lunch."

"A simple smoked salmon with potatoes and a suitable sauce, miss."

"Wonderful, Catra! Lead me to the table."

Lunch was a short affair, exercise truly gives you an appetite! After that I withdrew to the old sofa with a good book. However, as I lay there with Mrs. Christie's latest, I felt peckish. It's a strange thing, that you can have the heartiest meal and still have space for a little something more. Like I was at this scientific

lecture on molecules (I was accompanying Perfuma, her latest interest was holding the class) and there I heard the most remarkable thing. Do you know that molecules are so small, that if you were to fill a bin up to the edge with molecules, there still would be room for one more.

I decided that I needed a Gin and tonic to go with the book. As I had finished the classic witches brew I took a stroll by the kitchen to see if perhaps Catra had something left that I could chew on. In the small hallway that led from the living room to the serving room I froze. There was the damn clock. As ugly and off time as always. I emptied the drink in one go and then I fled the apartment. I heard Catra call after me, but I didn't care. I had to get away.

I didn't return until hours later. I planned to have a drink at the princess club, but then I decided it would be better for my physical condition to work out instead. There was no one there to spare with, so I went a few rounds with the old sandbag instead.

Around 4 o’clock I decided I had calmed down enough and so I returned to the lair, with the satisfaction of a good workout in my legs. I had come to the conclusion that the clock was my destiny and that I had just to accept that I would never be rid of it.

But as I walked down the street, someone called my name.

"Miss Greyskull! Miss Greyskull!"

I turned. And hadn't I been in the centre of the beehive I would have run like a wet cat in a sewer. It was Lady Little-Gore. She looked even more majestic and imposing now. I have to say, I was sweating like a penitenter on Sunday.

"Why, hello Lady Little-Gore. "

"Please, miss Greyskull. Call me Angella."

"Oh! Well, I shall then! Angella. That is. You."

She smiled, an actual kind smile, the one Glimmer said she was incapable of, but she's her daughter so her opinion doesn't count. "Always such an amusing company, miss Greyskull. Adora, I mean."

"Oh, it is not a problem, La...Angella. people call me all kinds of stuff all the time. So, what brings you to the old beehive?"

She looked at me for a moment. "Oh, you mean London? Ah well, it's business with I am afraid just to little pleasure. I've had a meeting with the board of the Lady Tories. Dreadful, I know. But it's a place I inherited from my mother. Oh, I ran into your Aunt Sharon! Interesting woman."

I say, of all the things you can say about Aunt Sharon, Interesting is the most neutral expression there is.

"And on the subject of relatives, I have that on the menu as well. In fact, I am on my way to tea right now! But I just saw you in the street and I needed a friendly face to cheer me up in between."

I smiled. "Glad I can help in anyway!"

"Oh, you are a big help, Adora! Oh, speaking of help! I almost forgot! I must thank you."

I hadn't the slightest idea what the matter was, but I decided to just go along. "Thank me? Oh, um… It was nothing! Just doing my… Greyskullian duty, you know."

"I assure you, it was far from nothing. That clock affair could have blown up to embarrassing proportions."

I had taken a shower after my visit to the club but now I was soaked again.

"The clock! He he yes. The clock. Would have been a bummer."

"It would have been much more than that! I… You can't imagine the scandal! No, Adora. It was…"

"Angie! Hoo hoo! Angie!"

She turned her head and waved to a short, dark haired woman. "Oh darn, peace is officially over. It's my sister-in-law. In a weak moment I offered to have tea with her. I will save you from her charms. And knitted sweaters. But that is just an ounce of my gratitude. Adora. As starters, you will always be a welcome guest at Brightmoon. Always." She put on her most polite smile. "Coming Casta!"

And she was gone. (Not literally. I could see her head over the crowd for well over ten minutes. Yes, that was how long I stood, dumbfounded.) I fled home to the old lair. Catra greeted me as I entered.

"Welcome home, miss. I assume your intermediate with the sandbag concluded with you victorious?"

"It was not! ...well, the punching was good, I feel my weak right improving a bit but that is beside the point! I met with Ang...Lady Little-Gore!"

"Indeed, miss."

"Indeedy indeed Catra! And do you know what she did?"

"She was going to have tea with Miss Gore I believe. "

"Miss...Gore?"

"His lordship's sister, miss."

"Yes, I know… but how do you...oh nevermind! The chambermaid?"

"Actually one of the younger girls in the kitchen. Flutterina. She can go far…"

"Nevermind whoever and their prospering future! This is about me and not her or Lady Little or whoever she was having with. Which apparently was this Miss Gore or whoever, that's not why I'm upset!"

"That would have been alarming, had that been the cause of it, miss," she added with her patented sneer, but at this moment I found it extremely annoying.

"Now see here! You stop being so Catra, Catra, and listen! Lady Little-Gore thanked me! For helping with the clock! THANKED ME! And she mentioned a scandal! The very scandal that stands in my very hallway! From what I gathered, once we had it loaded into Glimmer and Bows station wagon it would be out of my way. Really."

I had hoped for some kind of reverence or perhaps some remorse, but I got neither. She shrugged her shoulders and said, "We can't always get what we want, miss."

Oh, so she was still on the warpath towards me, aye? Well, two could play that game! I turned on the spot and left the room in silence. I was going to ignore her completely and add another month before mentioning the praise she got from Glimmer. But after a while, I began to calm down and actually think the situation through. All wasn't thunder and lightning. I had the damn clock, just give it to auntie and let the rest of the world and Catra burn for all I cared! At that moment, the phone rang. I answered it, showing Catra that I could be my own woman. It was Mista who called.

"So, um, Hello Adora."

I was still upset, and still hungry, but I tried my best to control myself. "What ho, mista. What can I diddle doddle do for you on this wibbly wobbly day?"

"...Please stop, Adora. I can't take you being you right now."

I decided that being quiet was the best virtue for the moment.

"Adora? Are you still there?"

"What? Oh yes yes! Shoot it out, old gal!"

"...You just can't stop, can you… Anyway, I was just going to tell you that we don't have to move. We… found a clock. So… Father is pleased or whatever."

"Oh! Jolly good then!"

"Yeah. So… I was going to ask if I could treat you to dinner tonight. To celebrate or something. "

"Oh! Well yes! Yes indeed!"

"Good. Marcinis at 8?"

"Will be there with oiled up jaws!"

We said goodbye and I hung up. I then proceeded to ring on Catra. There was no real point in being that angry for that long. And besides, I wanted her opinion on a suitable outfit for dinner. She materialized on the doorstep instantly.

"Miss?"

"Well, things are starting to look better! Mista just called."

"Indeed miss? What did she say?"

"She invited me to dinner tonight."

"Very good miss. May I suggest the red long sleeveless dress? At what time shall I have the car ready?"

"...7.30 would be enough."

"Very well, miss."

"She also said she had found a clock."

"Did she now, miss?"

"Yes. So… now they don't have to move. Jolly good, isn't it? A shame that you couldn't be as helpful as you usually are. But we can't always have a perfect score, right!?" I couldn't help but to put a little edge in my words. Catra had been extremely un-helpful and unsupportive in the matter. Let her have some of the old Greyskull wrath, that would teach her.

"True words Indeed, miss."

I continued, in a more pleased tone, "But I do wonder where they found one. I mean, " I said as I turned around to point at the clock that currently stood in my living room, "It's not like it's something common. Save for the one in Brightmoon, I haven't seen anyone else, and I would have remembered that! This clock was...the...ugliest...I have...seen…"

I pointed at nothing. The clock was gone. For the second time in two days there was nothing where it should be something!

I stared at the empty spot, then at Catra, then at the spot again, the same empty spot where the damn clock had stood just this morning. It was gone. I… I don't use foul language, but at that moment I wish I could have used some.

"Catra!"

"Yes, miss?"

"The clock!"

"Yes miss."

"It's not there!"

"Indeed it is not, miss."

"It was there right before, Catra!"

"Very perceptive of you, Miss Greyskull."

"Catra! What are we going to do? Mrs. Little-Gore will...and Glimmer… And AUNT SHARON! SHE WILL… "

Speak of the devil, they say. The doorbell rang the instant I didn't finish the sentence.

"Pardon me, miss." And she left. I don't pray very often but in the moment I assure you, I prayed to every god I could remember from school that it wouldn't be Aunt Sharon at the door. That, or that the clock would magically re-appear in the room. And while I was at it, I sneaked in a small wish for "Jubilee" to win at the track coming sunday. I mean, if the powers were to be in a good mood, better to use the opportunity, right? I immideately realised that putting any money on Jubilee would be a waste because at that moment, Catra re-entered.

"Mrs Shadow Weaver is here, miss Greyskull."

I was dead. I stammered, I had nothing to say. And the next moment, the imperative woman in question filled the room.

"Well, hullo, Aunt Sharon! How was your meeting with the conservative party?"

"Don't try to charm yourself out of it. And way to Little sherry. Adora… I imagine you failed?"

"Whu?"

"Oh, don't bother. I know that face. You had one simple task and you didn't make it. Shame. I can usually count on you."

"I… I am sorry."

"Well, you oughta be." She paused. " But luckily for you, it doesn't matter."

I stared.

"Do stop looking like a gutted fish, Adora. It's unbecoming."

"You...it doesn't matter?"

"Did I stutter? It doesn't matter anymore. I don't need it. Had you gotten it, I would have appreciated the effort. You'd at least proven to not be as useless as you usually are. But it's not crucial for me to have it anymore."

Since I had our last meeting itching right behind my forehead, my surprise was covering my whole body, I imagine.

"Yes." She was silent. I didn't want to ask. Frankly, I had no idea what to ask. I am not completely sure, but I got the distinct hunch that she actually looked away from under the glasses. "So," she finally continued, "Now you know. And…" she hesitated. "Thank you, Adora. " and with that, she left.

Catra materialised in the doorway right after. "I take it that Mrs. Shadow Weaver won't be staying for tea?"

I was still in so much of a chock I didn't bother to correct her. "No. She… she just wanted to say that she didn't need the clock."

"Indeed Miss? Well, that is awfully convenient, isn't it?"

"Well, yes! But we must call the police! Scotland Yard! The IRS! We have been burgled! Devilishly cunning pricks to break and enter...Wait a minute! You have been here all day, Catra! You must have seen the culprits!" But she shook her head.

"I am afraid, Miss Greyskull, that I didn't see anyone. I was out doing the daily shopping between 14.17 and 16.10. I can't completely rule out the possibility of another chain of events, but I do lean towards that the culprits were here during that time."

"Why are you so sure?"

"They left a note, miss."

I stared at the woman again. What was this? "Yes. This note was placed on the kitchen table as I returned. With your permission I shall read it. Ehrm. 'Ohoy scanty lassies! We have unburdened you of your possession! Your clock is now our booty! Do not try to search for us, you will never find us! Alonnsy! To adventure!

/Not Seahawk"

She neatly folded the paper and gave it to me to read. I read it intensely. "By jove! Sea Hawk!"

"The note specifically says that he was not involved, miss."

"Don't play me like a fool, Catra. This note has Sea Hawk all over him! Just how stupid do you think I am?"

She answered slowly "Not *that* much, miss. Of which I am glad."

I ignored that impasse. My foul mood was back. "And what am I going to say to Glimmer? She left it in my charge! ...without asking me, but still!"

"If you want my opinion, miss…"

"Oh please! Give me your opinion!" I was sharp, I didn't care! This situation was more than upsetting. She deserved some crossfire after all this!

"Very well, miss. Miss Little placed the clock here for you to take it to Sea Gate."

"What? How!?" I stared at Catra.

"It may take a while to explain, miss."

"Are you saying, *again*, I'm that stupid, Catra?"

She frowned. "I am saying, *Adora,* that this might take a while to explain and that you may want to sit down."

"Ah." I sat down. What else to do, really?

"This affair has been complicated. I told you on Thursday that I didn't have all the facts, just hunches. And I wanted to avoid the option of you having to steal it as long as I possibly could. Was there any way to avoid that? Yes, there was one option. Mrs. Weaver, as hell fire-ish she may yearn for something, only cared about acquiring the clock as long as Mrs. Little-Gore acknowledged the value of the clock. If there was a possibility to discredit the clock itself in the eyes of her Ladyship and his Lordship, they wouldn't want anything to do with it. And with Lady Little-Gore being a woman of high morale and refinement, to imply to her that it was in fact stolen goods under her roof, that would be enough to make sure she wouldn't care to have it disappear. That would solve that matter. However, then came the problem with Mrs. Anastassakis. She needed the clock and the replacement was an urgent matter to her. I realized that here was an opportunity to not only remove the problem from you, but also to make sure the piece in question got taken care of without having to involve somewhat more of a shady third part, miss."

"But… How could you know that Mista could steal it?"

Catra coughed discreetly "Mrs. Anastassakis is cunning and capable. And ruthless enough. I knew that if she was to get the tip and the opportunity, she would be able to nick it."

"So...When she showed up at Brightmoon...it was you who told her?"

Catra cleared her throat. "I may have mentioned your visit to Huntara."

"Dear me…" I paused. "But you could hardly have counted on two attempts to steal it?"

"As a matter of fact, I did, miss. It was obvious that for mrs. Anastassakis, the deed was more important than discretion. While there was but a 50/50 shot of them to succeed but there was still a good chance. And when they failed, well, my back-up plan was

for Miss Little and Mr. Planner to steal it, leave it here, and then tip mrs. Anastassakis again.”

“Blimey.” But now another question rose. “You said you knew that Glimmer and Bow would steal it? How? I told you about Mista, but I had no idea about them until that night?”

“Well, I may have to explain something to you. When I heard about the affair at Sea Gate, I realized something. The clock that mr Sea Hawk broke could not have been the real one. That one had, in fact, been stolen just a few weeks earlier. And the stolen clock must had been placed at Brightmoon Estate.”

“WHAT?” I ejaculated. But Catra continued, without a hitch.

“As you know, Miss Greyskull. Not only do I know Huntara, I also know Scorpia, Miss Little's maid. She did mention that Master Bertram had, a few weeks ago, made a model of said clock, just to impress his mentor, Lady Entrapta.”

“Who is that?”

“I believe she is known as ‘Wacky Lucy’, miss.” Wacky Lucy! Of course. The crazy inventor Bow always wanted me to invest in.

“Ah. So...He made a model. And somehow replaced Mista’s Old man's clock?”

"Yes. I believe it was originally a plan to just study a legendary piece of useless equipment and adjust it and improve it to actually work. Unfortunately, it wasn't possible. He only managed to make a lighter replica of the object in question. Now, he still wanted to show his mentor what he had done butt was Miss Little who suggested that Master Bertram should replace the Clock at Sea Gate with his model, as a partly a prank, partly as a bragging about her skilled Fiancee."

"...Yeah, that is very Glimmer. But how?"

“He was there as part of Master Sea Hawks ‘Crew’ a few months back I believe? He did it then."

"But… it's so heavy?"

"Scorpia was called in to aid." Catra coughed. "I asked her about it earlier today. It took some convincing, but she told me all. They asked her, and she obliged, but she wasn't very pleased with it. I believe that is why they asked you, miss."

“Ah! And when it broke, they heard about it and realized they had to replace it?”

“Indeed miss. They probably planned originally to reveal it to Mrs. Anastassakis as a joke. But time passed and the opportunity never came. At first it was just a matter of getting it back. Imagine their shock, miss, when they learned that Lord Little-Gore had found the clock hidden in his storage room. They realized that they had to get it away before mrs. Anastassakis would recognize it. Something that obviously wouldn’t happen, she is not that observant. But they didn’t know that.”

"But ...You seemed to know this on Friday! If you only asked Scorpia today, how could you be sure it was Glimmer who had taken it and replaced Mistas old man's junk with a fake in the first place?"

She coughed discreetly, while looking extremely smug at the same time.

"I did know that the clocks in question were very robustly built, and actually rather heavy. If it had been real, it wouldn't have broken. And it was fairly obvious from Miss Little's behaviour that she had a finger in it, Miss. I also took the liberty to sneak a peek into mr. Planner's workshop just to be sure. The blueprint was in the left drawer. You noticed, I hope, that mr. Planner did become a bit vague when asked why he didn't attend the last one. He was afraid they would find him out. Well, after that it was easy. When presented with evidence that her clock was stolen goods, Mrs

Little-Gore asked me to get rid of it. I suggested your home, to make sure that the police wouldn't associate the theft with Brightmoon estate."

"I say."

Again, she coughed. "Actually I mentioned to them that it was you, who with your sharp eyes noticed something aloof with the instrument in question, that you did recognize it as stolen and that it would be a great scandal if it came to the public's knowledge. But that you could take care of it."

"Catra!"

"I believe a small gratitude from your side oughta be in place, miss."

For once, I was not at a lack for words. "Catra! You have outdone yourself! This is brilliant! Fantastic! Wonderful! You… Ehm…" I paused, and brought up my wallet. "Here's a tenner from Glimmer. I realize now what it was for. She says thank you as well."

She took the money and bowed. "Thank you, Miss Greyskull. Miss Little's gratitude is worth very much to me."

I stood there in silence for a bit, collecting my thoughts.

“You say you had already arranged with The Ladyships for the clock to be transported here? But why let me and Glimmer and Bow carry on with the theft then?”

“Because it was funny, Miss.” Once again, she wore that face that made her look like a well-fed cat.

I raised my finger in a protest… and soon lowered it again. I decided to be the bigger woman (which I am, Catra is so much smaller than me) and turn another cheek. After all, she had saved me from a fate worse than… Not death but… something in that

line. "I say, Catra! And then Sea Hawk and Mista broke into the old lair."

She coughed discreetly. "They didn't actually break in, miss. Mrs Anastassakis was just here to see if she could have a drink with you to get her mind off her troubles. But you were out unfortunately. I may have mentioned the clock in question being in your possession as a gift from her Ladyship. I also mentioned myself going out shopping, and that you probably wouldn't notice it being gone until a few weeks had passed.

"But I did! And then there was the note!"

"Yes. Perhaps you should avoid mentioning that to mrs. Anastassakis. She values your friendship highly, miss, in spite of her harsh demeanour. And she loves her husband, strangely enough. He left it without her knowledge. That [I leave out Catras description of his intelligence for everyone's sanity]."

I sighed. "Ah well. For the good spirit, I shall pretend to be an unsuspecting fool. What was that, Catra?" There had been a slight louder cough coming from her.

"Nothing, miss."

"Thought so. But! I still can't see why you couldn't just keep me out of at least Mistas attempt! I suppose it was of some significance having me going along with Mistas plan, but I can't really see why."

"Ah. Well, His Lordship does like you, miss Greyskull. But he also has a very peculiar opinion about you. If he catches you doing something… eccentric… He is on his guard. He is a bit protective of his family and his belongings as you may have noticed? I imagined it would be easier to convince Lady Little-Gore with her husband's input. It would be possible without it, but it would simplify things greatly if he was onboard."

I leaned back onto the couch and sighed relieved. "So, finally it is all over. Mista has the clock so she won't have to move. Aunt

Sharon doesn't want it anymore so she is off my back for now. Glimmer thinks she has pulled a fast one on her parents and I am cleared of suspicion. Well, Catra. Hats off to you."

"I am glad I could be off service, miss."

I hesitated. But in the end, I realized that sacrifices needed to be made. "Catra…" I removed my hair tie. "Please brush my hair after dinner. I will only use this while horse riding from now on."

She bowed. And smiled, very widely. "A very wise decision, miss."

"What would I do without you, Catra?"

"Barely survive, I imagine, miss."

Later that night, hair brushed and floating freely over the old pillows, pyjamas on and laying in bed with her strong arms around me, I sighed again, satisfied. "I am so glad to have you, Catra."

"I am glad I can be useful, Miss Greyskull."

"Kiss me."

"May I remind you that you are to be up early tomorrow for the derby?"

"Screw the derby and kiss me."

"You are such an idiot, miss Greyskull."

She kissed me anyway. Then she snuggled closer and whispered " But you are my idiot, Adora" in my ear. And then she kissed me again.

The end.

Chapter End Notes

Well, that was it! Thank you for reading!

But Catra and Grayskull may return when you least expect it...

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